

## Overview

- Before the operation, The Black Dragon Society have sent out an exploration team (mostly of clones) to Goa Andesit. Many assets, including K'n-yani, have yet to return. The cave will not let them.
- Catching wind of Bulan picking itself up from scraps, they send in their best teams which include K'n-yani, cultists, clones, and humans. Their goal is to seize control of multiple realities to spread their influence, or otherwise somehow exploit the cave for their own use. The Agents will have to race against the Dragons.
- Countless humans across all realities have been lured to the cave in the same way as Operasi ANDESIT. If these humans are not strung across like meat hooks in a butcher's shop (the Stomach), they would have been processed by the Guardians and stuffed into carvings, made into plans, or picked apart to decorate the cave or to offer as gifts to the inhabitants.
- Decker, in his wish to disappear, has been living in the cave off the plants and the cave water. These, along with the cave's properties, have made him hit 0 SAN. He panics at seeing the Agents: their caffeinated resistance against the cave's effects makes them (and so him) a trackable anomaly. A Guardian will capture him. Whether the Agents choose to rescue him or not, they will hear his screams, go through the chamber of strung humans, and will find out what the Guardians do to their victims.
- The Dragon cultists make free use of Reverb: the Hounds and so Nessus will find themselves in the cave. Nessus, having worked with the Hounds and, thinking he has reasoned with them, is at 0 SAN.
- The Dragons and Agents will learn that the Heart is what keeps the cave alive, the Heart is what all the cave's inhabitants serve, and the Heart is what bears the ability to bend reality to one's will. The Dragons will want to rewrite history to benefit them.
- The Guardians will want the right host for the Heart, so that it (and so the cave) will be fully powered. Arisu will sacrifice herself to the Heart. The Agents can either try to kill her, or the Agents can try to remove her and have someone else take her place to seal the cave away from all realities, focusing all its power into making a new reality so that the cave will be dormant.

## Briefing

Location: Bulan safehouse, Jakarta

8 August 2011

The Black Dragon Society, under the guise of Kurotokage, took advantage of late Director Mulyani's death and have hijacked Bulan Anggrek Nusantara. If Bulan agents have not been eliminated by them, they have gone dark. All Bulan communication systems have been disabled as a safety measure by Elbert. Additionally, he helped Kiara gather what few remaining agents she can find in a moment's notice to dispatch them on what may be Bulan's final operation.

Before his death, the Manokwari director of West Papua relayed to Kiara that Goa ANDESIT, the cave from Operasi ANDESIT, has reemerged on the Jayawijaya Mountains. His immediate plan of action as Jakarta's director was to dispatch agents and the Jakarta HQ's more ample resources to the cave. He is unreachable and likely assassinated.

The Black Dragons, having intercepted this message, have set their sights on the cave. Kiara isn't sure what their plans are, but she knows that they'll learn of its time/space manipulation and reality

travelling ability from the Archives. Whatever they're planning, it can't be good -- especially combined with the Black Dragon's measures of interfering with Kurotokage and dismantling Bulan.

Kiara tells them to prepare arctic parkas, cold weather clothes, and boots. The Agents have the next day to get their affairs in order before what may be Bulan's final operation. At the following midnight, Kiara, Kit, and the Agents will fly 16h (with transit) to Wamena. Pulling every string she can with her military connections, Kiara has also arranged a helicopter from Wamena to Jayawijaya Mountains for speed and to scout for the cave from the sky. Elbert, having done all he can and not wanting to be deadweight in the field, will remain dark in Jakarta.

## Final Flight

Location: Wamena, West Papua

9 August 2011

Time: 4pm

Kiara, Kit, and the Agents fly at Midnight from Jakarta and, after two transits, arrive at Wamena at 4pm. The team will rest at a small, inconspicuous hotel near the hotel. Though it isn't strong, there is phone reception and wifi. The Agents will have the rest of the day to prepare for the 5am helicopter ride (to avoid mist) to Jayawijaya Mountains.

Kiara's military connection is the pilot and she's the copilot. Weapons, gear, and tactical armour are prepared. Kiara also has both a **flare gun** and a **radio** to signal the pilot if she makes it out. She also reminds everyone to eat their **caffeine pill**, including the pilot.

## The Mouth, Reprise

Location: Puncak Jaya, Jayawijaya Mountains

12 July 2011

Time: 6am

 *Arachnophobia - Half-Life: Alyx*

Despite biting wind and walls of white, the Agents find the cave all too easily. It's as if the storm herded them there -- this is how much the cave's power has grown in a few months. With Kiara's sternness, the reluctant pilot lowers the helicopter to the ground for the Agents to disembark. It will later be forced to land due to the cave's storm.

The ground is coated with snow, the temperature is below freezing thanks to windchill, and the thin air is hard to breathe. However, even though visibility is at an all time low in this mild blizzard, the protruding black cave maw with its unnaturally neat and plentiful blue, glowing patterns is unmistakable. From the outside of the cave, there are a number of differences compared to the last encounter with the cave:

- **INT** recalls that this time, the carvings at the entrance are already glowing. Though their glow curves the walls and traces a path into the cave, it's not bright enough to guarantee safe footing.
- **INT/ARCHEOLOGY/GEOLOGY** or a relevant science notices how the rock the cave is made out of is most definitely not what it was once made out of. It's also not made of the

surrounding ground -- its smooth, polished sheen that juxtaposes its patterned texture is most definitely foreign.

What is perhaps more obvious are the faint cluster of tracks where the Agents stand. **SURVIVAL/INT** reveals that the fresher snow over the tracks indicate that they're recent. Any older tracks may have been snowed over, but what's certain is that there has been a group of people here recently -- **SURVIVAL** marks this as being within a day ago. These tracks were made by the Black Dragon's team sent in less than a day ago.

There is nothing else to glean or do without setting foot into the cave. Keep track of the number of hours the Agents go without drink, food, or stimulants to withstand the cave's effects. When a stimulant's effect wears off, the Agent would be incredibly disoriented and will hallucinate realities closing in on them. Each hour in this state costs 1D4/1D8 **SAN**.

### Set Teeth on Edge

Inside the cave, the cold recedes and the air smells stale and damp. A narrow flight of stairs leading downwards meets the Agents. They will be forced to walk in a single file. Dim carvings wrap around them like starry constellations, vaguely tracing where the stairs lead -- the Agents will still need to use torches to properly see their surroundings. Perhaps, on their cold tongues, there is the slight tinge of the smell of flesh in the trapped air here -- or maybe it is just the Agent's imaginations.

Just like in Operasi ANDESIT, time and space are disparate here. All devices that tell time will stop at the time the Agents entered the cave. Electronic devices too fail to work here as well.

Once the Agents have traversed deep enough, the light of the entrance will disappear behind a curve, never to be found again. Walking back will set the Agents on an infinite stairwell going upwards. From then, it will not take long for the Agents to arrive at a chamber. But before then, Agents can feel a change in the stair's texture -- it is now strangely cobbled at the edges.

A bright source of light shone down on them reveal that the edges of each step has been embedded with rows, and rows, and rows, and rows of what the Agents have been treading on: unmistakably human teeth (**SAN** 0/1D4 Violence). Agents who lose more SAN may wonder how many human teeth there are, and how many humans they came from. Further inspection with **FORENSICS** show that the teeth vary with age, from fresh to dull, young to old -- both how long they've been here for, and how old their owner was.

Agents can also hear water -- or some liquid -- coming from beyond.

## Headspace

 *Severed from the Vortessence - Half-Life: Alyx*

At the end of the stairs is a chamber the Agents had once set foot in, but it is nearly unrecognisable. There are pots of flesh-plants of various shapes: vines stringing the walls, bushes tastefully lining the corners, and a cobbled path of teeth and bone in the smooth, black rock. The lake is still there but, being lined with a barrier of intricate rocks, looking more like a pond in a garden. At its centre is a fountain of sorts -- not made of stone, but more of a soft, translucent bud that opens and closes, pulsating like an organ with the flow of water. This chamber is significantly less primitive than it once was, looking like a lost civilisation that is flourishing back to life.

Rolling for **SEARCH/FORENSICS** shows that there are empty bullet shells on the ground. Also, to the side of the lake, a staircase spiraling downwards. **GUNSMITH/FORENSICS** can detect them to belong to light rifles. There are no bullet holes to be seen: not even in the dead k'n-yani floating on the lake, glowing a stellar, radioactive cyan (**SAN** 0/1D4). To inspect it, the Agents will have to wade into the lake or pull the body out. It is plain to see that there are no bullet wounds. There are, however, deep cuts and gashes **FORENSICS** deems to be too deep and long for a combat knife. Any skill check to check the k'n-yani's physiology is at -20%, as it predates modern human anatomy.

Drinking the lake's water causes an Agent to hallucinate a number of realities collapsing onto them (**SAN** 0/1). It will also immediately poison them: if the **5% Lethality** roll fails, the Agent makes a **CON** check (Success = 1 damage, Fumble = double 1D4 damage). Filtering the water does not give any advantage. Drinking a large amount of regular water, however, will.

There are not many tunnels or walkways built yet -- the Guardians are working on developing the cave for its inhabitants before the cave's Heart awakens them. The Guardians also have no purpose for them, as they can phase in and out of walls. However, some have been built for aesthetic purposes or for humans to wander into.

A grand, wide walkway leads to a smaller room, from which the Agents can see the silhouette of something small. The Agents can also pass through the lake as before. Past the walkway, there is a column glowing green with the shadow of many leaves wrapping around something inside.

## The Column

This column is the power source of this segment of the cave. Having acquired a surplus of life across realities, the Guardians have installed these columns at various points through the cave to charge it with more energy, so the Heart can redirect its energy towards more vital things.

These columns are identical to the ones in the Greenhouse's floors, but it isn't embedded in the ground, is smaller, and is more fragile at **10 HP**. Breaking it is a sure way of alerting a Guardian to apprehend the offender and to fix the column. Also like the Greenhouse's columns, there is a human wrapped and digested by plants.

Unlike the Greenhouse, these columns aren't for connecting to other realities as they're purely an energy source. Therefore, the humans inside do not need to have a beacon implanted into their chest. Any human is fine, though once they have been fully consumed, a new one will have to be inserted.

Going into the column sends the Agent to a new, temporary reality that represents their ideal life -- something the Guardians intentionally set up so the human will not resist as much. The reality is very real to the human. They will feel familiar and at home, as though they have always been a part of that reality. They will forget all they know, having their actual memories throw out and replaced with the ideal reality's hypothetical memories... unless they decide to leave.

**Controlling the column** requires them to have one foot in their ideal reality and one foot in the cave to eventually tear away from their dream life, costing **SAN** 1/1D4 and an equal amount in **WP**. However, the human can **choose not to leave** their ideal reality and will not lose any SAN from doing so. If the human has 0 WP, they will be stuck there forever.

## The Orbitals

The walkway opens to a domed room with the usual carvings stretching across its surface. There is nothing else besides the carving. It is a map room of realities -- those who attempted to understand the map from the previous operation will see layers upon layers of different carvings, spanning in all dimensions and beyond (**SAN** 0/1 and equal gain in Unnatural). Significantly more circular carvings are now glowing -- the cave has reached even more realities than before.

Agents who haven't attempted to understand the map may do so by losing **SAN** 1D4 and gaining the same amount in Unnatural. They will enter a trance-like state that will need to be broken by someone not studying the map.

The carvings form a map of different realities, universes, and points in time, with each circle being a Beacon and each line indicating a path. The map calibrates itself to have one particular Beacon be at the centre. This Beacon represents the current reality and time the Agents are in.

The small silhouette is a wet, black backpack, as if it was just from outside in the snow. It has been left open with a mechanical film camera (when developed, its film contains photographs of the cave's interior). There are tools for gathering samples, tubes containing the lake's water and some plants, and a dish of small rock samples. There is also a water bottle and some rations. A **pickaxe** and **rope** are attached to its side. Laying next to the backpack is a notebook: only some of its pages are filled with rubbings of the carvings, with Japanese notes annotating what the carvings represent.

There is no trace of whoever was here. It's as if they had simply disappeared.

## The Greenhouse

🎵 *Shadows Fore and Aft - Half-Life: 2*

The lake functions the same as it did before, climbing up to the waists of the Agents and stretching over the Greenhouse beneath it. Agents who fail a **SAN** roll (**SAN** 0/1) accept the fact space works unconventionally and realise they can will themselves to sink through the lake. They are able to drag other Agents with them. Agents who succeed their **SAN** roll refuse to comply with this lawless logic and are unable to pass through.

Agents who phase through need to roll **CON** against the suffocating stench of decay so strong, it settles on their tongue with each breath and stings their eyes. Failure causes the Agent to vomit and feel faint until they recuperate. Fortunately, there is a mild breeze circulating through this chamber - **SEARCH** reveals it's actually from walls contracting and expanding, and the lake being sucked in and out like a diaphragm (**SAN** 0/1 with equal gain in Unnatural).

The Agents remain dry. The lake glows overhead, but not brightly enough for the Agents to see. The glowing irrigation system on the walls now shine through the bushels of translucent plants cascading over them. The chamber truly looks like a massive greenhouse -- or maybe a botanical garden with how neatly and thoughtfully arranged everything is, enclosed by the rib-like thick strips of stone and ornamented by the clusters of glowing carvings. There is also a new addition of a spiral staircase ornamented with crisscrossing bones and interweaving flowers that leads up to the lake.

If the Agents search for the rows of large, thick, circular transparent panes, all of them contain the dark silhouettes of leaves and stalks. All of the columns are filled with beacon hosts. Agents who know what this means suffer 0/1D4 **SAN** Helplessness.

Like before, the plants' leafy texture has been replaced by soft tissue, and stems have been replaced by pulsing veins (0/1 **SAN**). Turquoise water runs through them and stains their cells. A **SEARCH** check indicates the rotting stench is from the soggy, blue, flesh-like things stuffed into the carvings. A successful **BIOLOGY** or **SURGERY** check reveals the following:

- Skin, muscle, and various organs were shredded and stretched to fit inside the carved lines.
- All the carved circles, regardless of its size, have a heart forced into them. The hearts are undoubtedly human, and all of them have a chunk torn out of them.
- These organs aren't decomposing. They look and smell like they have been denatured by acid. These organs are being digested.

Realising that all the carvings in this chamber are stuffed with organs for the first time costs 0/1D6 **SAN** from violence and an equal gain in **UNNATURAL**. Inspecting it for a second time still costs 0/1D4 **SAN** Violence.

In the dead silence, it is easy to detect the sound of wet leaves squelching and rustling.

"Rachel? You're not supposed to be here."

Seeking escape from the world, John Decker was lured into the cave many, *many* months ago and has been stuck here ever since. His haggard, untrimmed hair and his beard fails to hide the gauntness of his face, and his damp hoodie hangs loosely and heavily over his malnourished frame and thin limbs.

Being trapped here for so long, Decker had long lost track of time as the Guardians keep filling in whatever marks he makes on the walls. Decker is delusional at 0 SAN, incapable of holding a conversation without raving and straying into insanity. (He has a better chance at responding to Rachel, however.) He has accepted his current way of life as perfectly normal, living off eating the plants and drinking the lake's water. He is also very, very distressed by the Agents' presence.

The reason Decker has been able to hide from the Guardians is because he did not resist the cave's individual flow of reality. The caffeine pills the Agents have taken, however, disrupt it. This jarring anomaly makes it very easy for Guardians to hunt the Agents down -- and now they're here with Decker.

Decker will yell at the Agents, telling them to get away from him, yelling 'They'll find you and they'll find me' and resorting to violence if needed. In his malnourished state, it is very easy to restrain him. This may not be a wise decision, as a **Guardian** will come after them.

## Setting an Example

 *Welcome to the Annual Blackwood Winter Getaway - Until Dawn*

If unrestrained, Decker books it for the stairs to climb up and out of the lake to the **column**. He smashes it, alerting a Guardian, throws out the shriveled human inside (**SAN** 0/1 Violence) and steps into the column, letting its plants take root into him (**SAN** 0/1). As the Guardian approaches, the Agents see the smooth, flat wall fragment into a spiral pattern of scales that unfurl and open up a tunnel. Decker immediately tears himself away from column, the plants shriveling back into themselves, and he darts into the tunnel. The Agents would be wise to follow him.

If they do, the last Agent is able to make it into the tunnel just as it closes. The tunnel is cylindrical, dark, small, and *alive*. The tunnel pulses like a vein, small scale-like fragments vibrating off the walls, the ceiling, the floor like angry scales. It pulses and pulses, gaining on the Agents. The scales gush and flood the surfaces of the tunnel.

Like water forced through a pipe, it catches up to Decker and bursts out of all surfaces. From above, below, and the sides, scales launch at Decker. He screams and pleads to be released. The Agents feel a wave of prickles on their skin, as if the scales too were swarming all over Decker's flesh, invading his form, coiling into his desperate lashes. The scales close in until all is covered in black, shiny scales, except his single reddened eye.

A final scale wraps over it. Then, all the scales are pulled back into the tunnel's surface, dispersing in all directions. The tunnel falls still, but Decker's yells echo further down the tunnel. (**SAN** 0/1D6)

Unlike in Operasi ANDESIT, Decker's yells are not an illusion. **ALERTNESS/SURVIVAL** can pinpoint his location being deeper in the tunnel. Though the Guardians can sense where the Agents are, they aren't concerned with the Agents for now as well: the cave has enough beacons, and there is no rush in activating all the columns as they have an surplus of humans to use.

As for the Agents, there is no turning back: the only path left is onwards. But those who succeed **ALERTNESS** catch onto a detail that may have rushed passed the other Agents -- the k'n-yani body on the lake has disappeared.

## Down the Gullet

The Agents will walk, and walk, and walk. In uniform darkness and structures, there is no way to determine the passage of time or the distanced traversed -- there is only the increasing soreness slowly wrenching their feet and legs. Decker's yells continue to echo, but the Agents can hear them grow weak and frail, faltering into chokes and groans, losing hope.

The cold has ebbed away the more the Agents walk, an uncomfortable heat making the air in this tight and narrow space heavy and stifling, the humidity collected from sweat sticking onto the Agents beneath their cold weather gear making each breath stuffy and moist -- yet it does nothing to their raw throats cut dry by cold, still recovering from the adrenaline-charged gasps from being chased by the Guardian.

Suddenly, silence. Only the Agent's breaths and footfalls are heard. Soreness begins to grip their shoulders from the weight of your bags. There is, however, little room to stretch away from the smooth, black walls. Or the jagged, rough, scales, maybe. It's hard to tell if the glints of light are playing tricks on the Agents' unfocused eyes, or if the tunnels spiraling is just in the Agent's head or not. Not retaking a caffeine pill soon will induce **SAN** 1D4/1D8.

## Peristalsis

When the Agents continue, a breeze far from fresh meets them -- air is being moved around through pores and valves that begin to dot the interior of this tunnel. Further down, the tunnel widens and the valves multiply, passing unfamiliar smells to mix a concoction in this gas tube. With the valves opening with a whistle and closing with a hiss rhythmically, it is like walking through the interior of a wind instrument.

Though the tunnel is still made of the same black, shiny rock, the valves are made of an obviously different material similar to the plants. Shining a light around shows that there is a similar irrigation system of glowing cyan water connecting the valves. The valves themselves are made of a substance similar to the plants.

Walking onwards, the Agents step into a puddle. Ahead of this puddle mixed with blood, sitting below a valve, is wet SUCBA gear. At the end of the tunnel is one massive valve that spans the entire diameter of the tunnel.

Then, the tunnel trembles with a low groan. The massive valve, with a squelch, twists open. All valves open, hissing air, and the column contracts, shrinking the space. The Agents lose their footing at the lurch as the tunnel declines steeply. Like an ocean current, the series of contractions force the Agents through the valve and down, down, down, tumbling blindly in the dark with flashlights showing the meaty texture around them before flickering off. (SAN 0/1)

## The Meat Hangers

 Coetaneous Entanglement - Half-Life: Alyx

The Agents are spat out on gelatinous but solid ground. As they pick themselves off the smooth surface, they can feel their clothes unsticking from the ground. It is warm here. It is pitch-dark. Agents will need light to see.

*Can you see it? Past the viscous, translucent walls and their slick sheen, inside the broad walls bowing towards you, inside the ceiling curving like the moon, inside the soft ground you stand on. The gallery of life is framed above, below, and around you. People of all ages, sizes, races, and genders stand straight and silent in rows like books shelved in the walls, in the ceiling, and even beneath your feet as you tread on their heads. Each one hails from their own unique path of life, and yet, all those paths ended here: livestock hanging on meat hangers, suspended in space and time, waiting, waiting, waiting... (SAN 0/1D6)*

This is where the Guardians store the humans they've harvested to be dissected, taken apart, put to use for the cave and leaving nothing to waste. Each person has their eyes closed and is suspended in time, maintaining their bodies to be kept alive for maximum freshness. Breaking the barrier to free a person requires breaking the fabric of space and time, mending it back together, and having control over the cave --- only the Guardians can remove people.

**FIRST AID/MEDICINE/SURGERY/SURVIVAL** can detect the extremely subtle rise and fall of each person's chest -- they are all alive, but seem to be in a very deep sleep. **ALERTNESS** reveals a gentle grumbling undertone around the Agent. **SEARCH** leads the Agent to the humans closest to where they came from -- suspended in the walls are a group of people dressed in black tactical gear. Closest to where the Agents came from is the K'n-yani from earlier, bearing the same scars.

The space in this room is finite, but the space past its walls, ceilings, and floor span to infinity, giving a similar effect of standing in a room full of mirrors. The room itself is small. In its centre is a **column** that isn't glowing. Walking around it shows that the column is open. Leaning next to it is **Johanna Mulyani**, asleep.

Waking Mulyani up sends her into a delirium a caffeine pill can fix, and she will note its effectiveness but is worried about it not being enough. Kiara sheepishly jokes about overpreparing two bottles.



Mulyani tells the Agents that when Nyi Roro Kidul's domain closed in on her, she suddenly ended up in a room full of valves. The room then moved her here. In complete darkness, she felt her way towards this structure, and decided to use it as a defensive shelter against... whatever. However, she made a mistake of stepping into it. It took her great strength, especially since it was tempting to stay, but she willed the column to open for her to leave. She has not seen or heard anyone else enter this room -- the Guardians don't need to access this room to store people.

An Agent will have to step into the column to create an opening to the next room. It will close behind them.

### Johanna Mulyani, Skinripper Host

The valves from the previous section passively take matter from realities the cave is connected to. This includes taking in Mulyani -- when she was swept away in Nyi Roro Kidul's domain, the wrong place crossed with the wrong time, and a valve ended up sucking her in and expelling her in the cave.

At the same time, a **skinripper** was also sucked in. It killed Mulyani, took over her corpse, and was able to escape being processed and being placed in the meat hangers. Having all the personality and memories of Mulyani, the skinripper will parade as her until there's an opportunity to grab the pills and run.

## Hound Hunt

 *Triple Entanglement - Half-Life 2*

The Agents arrive in a spacious, elegant, circular room complete with a chandelier made of crystals. The room glows blue, and carved into marble-like pillars are humanoid figures in dance crowned with pale flowers. These humanoids are distinctly not human: they are proportionally squatter, with squarer and harder features.

Opposite to where the Agents stand are tall, grand double doors nested within a doorframe of bones. Sitting between the doors and the Agents is a glowing **column** (10 HP). It mimics the aesthetic of the pillars, crowned with flowers. Soon, there is a glint of light in the crevice of a carving: two **Hounds of the Angles** unfold into the space around them. They shake their heads, raising their 'noses' to the air, seemingly blind to the Agents right in front of them. (**SAN** 1D6/1D20)

Due to its round shape, the ballroom throws the Hounds' senses off. They patrol, struggling to find specific energy and reality signals among a messy, entangled pool of them. Therefore, Agents can roll **STEALTH** to evade them. If they are near a Hound, it is made at -20%. Failing will set a Hound on them.

The **column** at the centre of the room can be exploited. Due to its circular nature, the Hound wouldn't go near it but may try to destroy it to get the person inside. If damaged, a **guardian** will appear the first time its initiative is reached and will attack the offender. It can also be used to open the **doors**.

## The Hound of the Angles

This terrifying, geometric entity boils into our four dimensions from sharp angles and edges. Its body is composed of a thousand shards of glittering, razor-sharp fragments of space-time which move and reform in the vaguest outline of a quadrupedal predator. It hunts in a similar manner to a dog, wolf or tiger, stalking prey, taking it down, and rending it to death, leaving behind only a bloody mess before vanishing with its victim's remains into some inscrutable corner of reality.

**STR 25 CON 25 DEX 20 INT 15 POW 20**

**HP 25 WP 10 SAN n/a**

**ARMOR:** See **INCONSTANT FORM**.

**SKILLS:** Alertness 90%, Angular Apport 75%, Stealth 50%, Track (via extradimensional means) 95%, Unnatural 50%.

**ATTACKS:** Shard Sweep 65%, damage 2D6 (see **SHARD SWEEP**).

Shard Swarm 70%, Lethality 10% (see **SHARD SWARM**).

**ANGULAR APPORT:** On a successful Angular Apport skill roll, the hound can leap into or emerge from any sharp, physical angle—a corner of a room, the lip of a table, or even the hinge on a pair of glasses—effectively teleporting between those two points instantly no matter the distance. In this manner they pursue their prey, so outrunning them is an unlikely outcome, no matter the speed of escape.

**CURVED SPACE:** Exposure to large areas composed of curves, spheres or circular surfaces causes the hound's "swarm" of shards to lose coherency. The hound is well aware of this weakness, and does its best to avoid and flee such areas. Each turn of exposure to such a space causes the hound 1D6 damage. If it reduced to 0 HP from exposure to curves, the hound disintegrates and seems to fold out of three-dimensional space (likely returning it to its place of origin).

**INCONSTANT FORM:** The hound can fold, change, stretch, extend and warp its form in amazing ways, altering its size as needed from moment to moment. It can effectively attack anyone within 10 meters by directing its form to a new location. Because it has no "body" and is instead composed of a thousand swirling, reflective shards of space-time, the hound is immune to all attacks except hypergeometry.

**INHUMAN STATS:** A test of a stat with a score of 20 or higher is a critical success on any roll up to the stat's score, and on any roll of matching digits except 100, which fumbles.

**SHARD SWEEP:** The hound unleashes two "limbs" composed of shards, peppering a target with 2D6 damage. It ignores body armor but can be blocked by cover.

**SHARD SWARM:** The hound engulfs the victim in a swirling mass of shards, rendering the target down to a bloody mess with a Lethality attack of 10%. It ignores body armor but can be blocked by cover.

**SAN LOSS:** 1D6/1D20.

## Guardian of the Cave

**STR 40 CON 40 DEX 20 INT 10 POW 20**

**HP 40 WP 20 SAN n/a**

**ARMOUR:** 5 points of armour (see **HYDROPHYTE**)

**SKILLS:** Emergence 75%, Extension 50%, Swan Song 75%, Unnatural 50%

**ATTACKS:** Aggregate Scales 65%, damage 2D4 (see **AGGREGATE SCALES**)

Tidal Wave 40%, damage 6D6 (see **TIDAL WAVE**)

Harvest 40%, Lethality 20% (see **HARVEST**)

**AGGREGATE SCALES:** The Guardian shoots out an appendage of scales at a target up to 10m away, inflicting 2D4 damage and pinning the target. While it can be blocked with cover, the Guardian can also use the cover to pin the target, if possible. The Guardian can only pin one target at a time this way.

**EMERGENCE:** The Guardian can sink into a carving at one location and instantly travel to another carving at a different location, so as long the carving is made of the same unique minerals the cave is composed of. This travel includes interdimensional travel, and the carvings also includes the Beacon's carving.

**EXTENSION:** As an extension of the cave, the Guardian is capable of manipulating reality only when in its domain.

*Warp Surfaces* allows the Guardian to fold floors, bend walls, and sink ceilings to impede movement within a 20m range. This imposes a -20% penalty to any skills that needs good balance, or to any skills that involve movement. This can also be used to force targets to move.

*Rewind* shifts a target other than itself, living or non-living, back to its physical state 1 round ago. This includes the target's location and physical ailments, like hit points. Mental states and memories remain unchanged.

**HARVEST:** While a target is pinned, the Guardian can reach through the target's chest and attempt to pull their heart out of their body with its scales, dealing Lethality 20%. On a fail, the Guardian instead clumsily tears some other part of the target.

**HYDROPHYTE:** Though the Guardian's scales are physically tangible, the Guardian itself is capable of liquifying, granting the ability to squeeze through small spaces or to spread itself across a large surface area. It has 5 armour that absorbs all attacks except hypergeometry. Additionally, a firearm's successful lethality does not destroy the Guardian, but inflicts HP damage equal to the Lethality rating. Lethality rolls from explosions have full effect, causing the Guardian to fragment.

**INHUMAN STATS:** A test of a stat with a score of 20 or higher is a critical success on any roll up to the stat's score, and on any roll of matching digits except 100, which fumbles.

**SWAN SONG:** Ultrahigh frequencies are emitted by the Guardian's shuffling scales. Upon failing an INT check, the target is compelled to offer themselves to the Guardian. This trance can be broken by another INT check or by harming the target.

**TIDAL WAVE:** With a successful attack roll, the Guardian can spread its scales and divide its damage dice among up to six victims within reach. Each victim may attempt to Dodge the Guardian's attack roll.

**SAN LOSS:** 1/1D10

## The Nexus of Greek Hounds

At 0 SAN, Nessus has somehow, after a long period of bartering and sacrificing much sanity, struck an agreement with the Hounds of Angles, saying he will bring them to the one who created Reverb. His first attempt was Operasi ZAITUN, where the hounds tracked Nelly by her energy signature. Though they are capable of doing so, they are guaranteed to find anyone who has ingested Reverb, hence Nessus' attempts at drugging Nelly.

With the hound's help, they have warped him into the cave. Nessus has told them that killing anyone inside is bound to help. Therefore, the Hounds are set on killing anyone they detect.

## After the Hunt

 *Surgeon Attack - Outlast*

Have Agent Deianira roll **DODGE**. **Nessus** will restrain Nelly and reject Reverb into her. This takes two rounds. However, if Nelly succeeds her dodge, Nessus will take one round to stab and inject Reverb into her. A number of things can happen:

- Nessus is unarmed and injected with Reverb. The Hounds sense this betrayal and shoot through the passage. Nessus yells at them and throws blame, saying how Nelly is the one who made the drugs and how she should be their target. Not caring for anything besides the way things are, the Hounds take him down and rip him into inconceivable shreds, and vanishes into a corner, leaving nothing behind.
- Or, the Agents kill Nessus. Kiara takes the needle and injects it into him, and the Hounds kill him.

The Agents are now standing in a hallway with floors tiled with royal patterns. This is when Mulyani takes charge. She notes how that if the Guardians wanted to kill them and were able to track them this entire time, they would've done so already. (This is because the Guardian is counting on one of them to be the Heart's host.) Therefore, this would be a good time to rest if they wanted to.

If the Agents rest, they catch Mulyani steal the caffeine pills, shedding her human skin, and running away. Otherwise, Mulyani offers her help in carrying equipment and offers Kiara to carry the pills.

*"They're light but bulky. They take up a lot of space... did anyone here bring small plastic bags or something like that? I can help transfer them. Save space."*

Obviously, as soon as Mulyani holds the two bottles, she transforms and runs.

## Journey to the End of the World

Mulyani, or rather the Skinripper, sprints out of the hallway into a balcony lining a large, circular, underground tower that plunges downwards. Cast in blue, it looks like the marbled interior of a paleolithic castle. More circular balconies lie beneath at countless levels. Looking straight down induces a **CON** save: failure induces intense vertigo.

Like the points of a star, hallways extend out from the circular balcony. The Skinripper scuttles blindly into one of them, where the Agents can hear (or see, if fast enough) glass shrieking and shattering as a **Guardian** impales the skinripper with all of its scales, before retracting and fanning out to sweep the remains away. (1/1D10 **SAN**)

## Breakfast is Served

This long room, strange in its humanness, resembles a line kitchen, complete with twin long stone elevated slab for counters, glowing light fixtures overhead, and two Guardians between the counters. The side of the wall closest to the Agents, unlike the other marble-like walls, is made of the same viscous, translucent membrane as the room full of humans frozen in time. One of the Guardians flow over the counter, its scales separating to sweep the rem

Whether the Agents are detected by the Guardians or not, it does not matter. The Guardians do not care about the Agents right now. If the Guardians wanted them dead, they would've tracked them earlier on. However, the Guardians are curious about these resilient humans, thinking they may be suited for the host of the Heart. They will only attack if the Agents interrupt their work or damage their surroundings.

On the counters, neatly arranged, are human body parts sorted into matching organs and limbs in containers and on the shelves spanning upwards. One human has recently been disassembled as is

being sorted by one of the Guardians. As its scales deftly manipulate its head to cut through its skull, the head faces the Agents. **Vikal** recognises the face as his mentor's (1/1D4 **SAN** Violence for Vikal, 0/1D4 **SAN** Violence for the others).

Vikal also recognises the man the sweeping Guardian pulls out from the membrane wall. It is another copy of his mentor, though he looks slightly different. The Guardian carefully undresses him, laying the shirt flat on top of black tactical gear and a familiar black hoodie. Concluding Decker has been killed this way costs Rachel 1/1D6 **SAN** Helplessness (0/1 for other Agents).

Staying and watching the Guardian pull Vikal's mentor apart costs 0/1D4 **SAN** Helplessness (0/1D6 for Vikal). Looking for Decker's remains and identifying it as such (such as looking for his head) costs Rachel 0/1D4 **SAN** Helplessness.

At the end of this room is a **stairwell** leading down.

## The Sleeping Chambers

The stairs don't make logical sense. Similarly to the entrance of the cave, it keeps leading the Agents lower and lower, the end never in sight. The cave is sending the Agents to where the Heart is -- and to where the surviving Black Dragon members are.

The Agents enter a large room. Glowing amniotic sacs filled with turquoise water sag off the walls like ripe fruit. The sacs fill the walls high above the Agents, illuminating an infinite sequence of light above them. Within each sac is a humanoid, curled and slumbering like an adult-sized foetuses, waiting to be born. **INT/ARCHEOLOGY** draws the connection between these humans and the pillars from the room with the Hounds -- the pillars are likely representative of these humans.

Directly in front of them is the largest **column** yet. It is glowing. Familiar faces surround it: Artem, Apollo, Daniel, Arisu, and Director Hiroto.

## The Heart

 *The One They Call the Witch - Octopath Traveler*

Director Hiroto immediately instructs the other clones to protect the Heart. While Hiroto stays on the upper level, away from the Agents on the lower level, the clones will fight the Agents. Artem and Apollo will taunt Kuro. Everyone, including Hiroto, turns into pink mush upon death.

### Apollo?

**HP:** 10

**ARMOUR:** 5

**SKILLS:** Firearms 40%, Light Rifle: 10% lethality, 1D12 dmg, 3 AP, 30 ammo cap

### Arisu?

**HP:** 11

**ARMOUR:** 5

**SKILLS:** Firearms 50%, Light Rifle: 10% lethality, 1D12 dmg, 3 AP, 30 ammo cap

### Artem?

**HP:** 10



**ARMOUR:** 5

**SKILLS:** Firearms 70%, Light Rifle: 10% lethality, 1D12 dmg, 3 AP, 30 ammo cap

**SAN LOSS:** 0/1 Unnatural

**Daniel?**

**HP:** 13

**ARMOUR:** 5

**SKILLS:** Firearms 40%, Light Rifle: 10% lethality, 1D12 dmg, 3 AP, 30 ammo cap

**Hiroto?**

**HP:** 8

**ARMOUR:** 5

**SKILLS:** Firearms 50%, Light Rifle: 10% lethality, 1D12 dmg, 3 AP, 30 ammo cap

When Hiroto dies or when an Agent tries entering the Heart, Hiroto yells that there is no time to make new discoveries, and tells Arisu to fulfill her destiny.

## Where Red Blooms

 *Moment of Truth - Octopath Traveler*

The real Arisu suddenly appears and offers herself to the Heart. The Heart takes on a flesh-like appearance as a mix of turquoise and red blooms through a mockery of veins and arteries, causing flesh-flowers to blossom off the vessels. As Arisu breathes, so does the entire chamber. The amniotic sacs seem to respond in kind, inflating and deflating like lungs. Arisu is now the Heart of the cave. Glowing beacons begin to pulse.

The Agents' memories begin to flicker, foreign memories trying to rewrite themselves as original and true.

### Japanese agents:

*You feel a burst of nationalistic pride that has been ingrained since kindergarten, with how Japan has spread its great culture around the world, is rich with resources and power, and is the forefront of advancement. The future of your country outshines anyone trying to cast shadows of accusation and lies onto them. The world truly is your oyster.*

### Indonesian agents:

*You recall fear and oppression throughout your entire life. On the day they were nearly independent, Japanese troops brought a strange power that massacred hundreds that day that was only described as 'mythological, inhumane'. Indonesia is currently a Japanese colony. Anyone who says otherwise vanishes, and after the time the islands' shores were stained red with blood, no one dares fight back.*

### Other agents:

*Japan is the current global superpower. With their military might of unknown origins, their reach, and their resources, no countries dare to touch them. The most people can do are rallies*

*and protests -- after all, who wants to mess with a country that made an incoming nuclear bomb disappear and reappear in the US?*

By being in control of the Heart and so the cave and its power, Arisu is rewriting reality to fit the Black Dragon's ideal reality. If she is not stopped, this ideal reality becomes truth.

There are a number of ways to destroy Arisu, the Heart:

- Straight up gun Arisu down. This is not the optimal solution.
- The Agents can weaken Arisu by destroying the 16 beacons in the room.
- Breaking all the beacons fully breaks her connection to the Cave, essentially reducing the Heart to 0 HP. Arisu goes unconscious but must be removed from the still-glowing Heart.

The humans in the sacs can't be destroyed. But, the Heart can materialise scales out of thin air to attack and protect.

🎵 *Daughter of the Dark God - Octopath Traveler*

*(Let players add whatever song they want to the final fight!)*

### **Arisu, the Heart**

**STR** 20    **CON** 40    **DEX** 20    **INT** 16    **POW** 20

**HP** 160    **WP** 20    **SAN** n/a

**ARMOUR:** 5 points of armour (see **SHATTERPROOF**)

**SKILLS:** Extension 50%, Unnatural 50%

**ATTACKS:** Aggregate Scales 65%, damage 2D4 (see **AGGREGATE SCALES**)

Tidal Wave 40%, damage 6D6 (see **TIDAL WAVE**)

Harvest 40%, Lethality 20% (see **HARVEST**)

**AGGREGATE SCALES:** Arisu shoots out an appendage of scales, inflicting 2D4 damage and pinning the target. While it can be blocked with cover, the Guardian can also use the cover to pin the target, if possible (like to follow up with Harvest). The Guardian can only pin one target at a time this way.

**EXTENSION:** As an extension of the cave, Arisu is capable of manipulating reality.

*Warp Surfaces* allows Arisu to fold floors, bend walls, and sink ceilings to impede movement within a 20m range. Targets can roll **DEX/DODGE** to contest this attack. On failure, the target(s) falls prone (+20% to incoming attacks, must Move on next round to stand). On success, the target(s) have -20% to checks on the next round.

This has a special effect on stairs: Arisu can crush a stairwell, dealing **20% lethality** that automatically hits.

*Rewind* shifts a target other than itself, living or non-living, back to its physical state 1 round ago. This includes the target's location and physical ailments, like hit points. Mental states and memories remain unchanged.

**HARVEST:** While a target is pinned, the Guardian can reach through the target's chest and attempt to pull their heart out of their body with its scales, dealing Lethality 20%. On a fail, the Guardian instead clumsily tears some other part of the target.

**SHATTERPROOF:** The Heart provides 5 armour that absorbs all attacks except hypergeometry. Additionally, a firearm's successful lethality does not destroy Arisu, but inflicts HP damage equal to the Lethality rating. However, destroying a beacon automatically inflicts 10 damage.

**INFINITY:** As the Heart, Arisu has absolute power and control over the cave. As she can materialise scales out of thin air, Arisu's range is infinite and she can attack from anywhere.

**INHUMAN STATS:** A test of a stat with a score of 20 or higher is a critical success on any roll up to the stat's score, and on any roll of matching digits except 100, which fumbles.

**TIDAL WAVE:** With a successful attack roll, Arisu can spread her scales and divide its damage dice to targets on the same level within a 5 x 5 square. Each target may attempt to **DODGE** this attack roll.

**SAN LOSS:** 1/1D10

## Home

When Arisu is destroyed and the Heart is left empty, the amniotic sacs go dark one by one, as does all sources of light and life. But despite the arteries and veins shrinking back into the Heart and its flowers withering away, the Heart can be destroyed, but cannot be killed. Its pieces remain ever-glowing, as does the circular imprint of where it stood. The Heart will rebuild itself slowly, like watching grass grow, but surely, until it is strong enough for the cave to return to its former power.

An Agent will need to offer themselves to the Heart to be able to open an exit back to where they started. Inside the Heart, the Agent is halfway between reality and their ideal world. Both worlds feel as dreamlike and as real as each other. They feel as though, in the Heart, they can forever detach themselves and the cave away from all realities, forever locking it to their ideal world.

This Agent can either follow their companions out of the cave to the mountains. Or, this Agent can remain in the Heart, erasing the cave's existence across space and time to instead forget everything and fully realise their ideal world, imprisoning themselves in their dreams forever.

No matter the outcome, knowing they've put some sort of end to this madness, regardless of means or cost, restores 1D10 **SAN**. If an Agent decides to offer themselves to the Heart, their sanity is restored to **POWx5**.

## Epilogue

🎵 *Bunga Anggrek - Sampul Surat NonaRia*  
*Rhapsody - Fantasia*